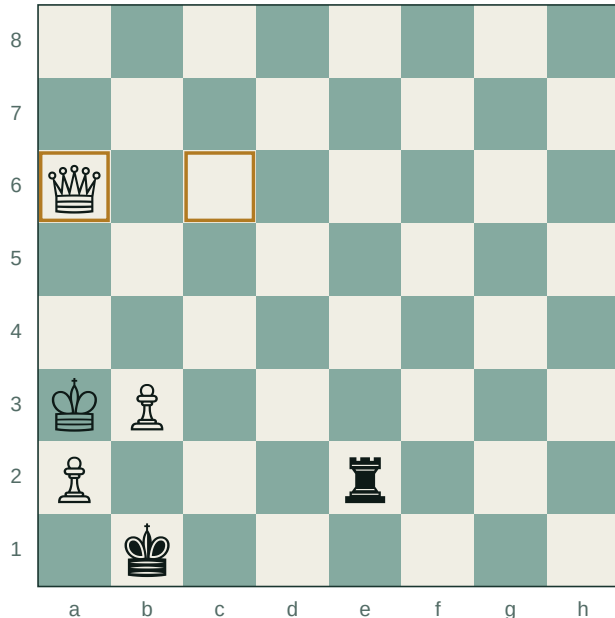


Queen-and-rook endings: Black, move 44

Queen-and-rook endings

Black to move



Previous move: 44.Qxa6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

44...Rxa2+ 45. Kb4 Rxa6

44...Rxa2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on a2. Recorded reply: **45.Kb4**.

45...Rxa6 The rook captures the queen on a6.

At the end, nominal material is White 1 / Black 5 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +10. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +10: the balance goes from -6 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not activate the king as casually as in a pure pawn ending. The remaining heavy pieces can still generate a mating net.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

When queens and rooks remain, mating threats coexist with endgame pawn races. Coordination and king shelter remain essential even on a sparse board.

HOW TO LOOK

Look for heavy-piece batteries, skewers, and checks that force a defender away from a promotion square or pawn.

The defending king is on a3. Geometrically undefended: queen on a6. Check for tactical protection.